

Session 1: What on Earth Is the Hebrew Bible?

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew Bible can present particular challenges for different people, such as talking animals, genocide, the portrayal of God, and how to truly apply this ancient text to our modern lives.
- When approaching the Hebrew Bible, it is helpful to be aware of our own assumptions and questions and to pay attention to the intent of the biblical authors.

Does Christianity Need the Old Testament?

One of the goals of this class is to learn how to read the collection of narratives and poetry that make up the Hebrew Bible (Old Testament). We want to learn how to do that without imposing our own cultures, agendas, preconceived notions, etc., onto the text. Instead, we want to learn how to understand what the biblical authors intended to communicate through these ancient texts.

“One of the most fundamental questions which has faced theology and the Church in every age ... is whether or not Christianity also needs an Old Testament. Is the Old Testament to be thrown away as obsolete, or preserved as a relic from days of yore, or treasured as a classic and read by scholars, or used occasionally as a change from the New Testament, or kept in a box in case it should be needed some day? Or is the Old Testament an essential part of the Christian Bible, with continuing validity alongside the New Testament?”

Baker, D.I. (2010). [*Two Testaments, One Bible: The Theological Relationship Between the Old and New Testaments*](#). IVP Academic. Cited in Alexander, T. Desmond (1998), “[Royal Expectations in Genesis To Kings: Their Importance for Biblical Theology.](#)” *Tyndale Bulletin*, 49 (2). 191-192.

Reflection Question

What are common experiences you or those in your context have with the Hebrew Bible? What are some ways to move through challenges?